

1 SOCIETY

Discussion point

Discuss with a partner.

- 1 Is attitude to time in your country more like Brazil or Australia?
The attitude in my country is ...
- 2 What advice would you give someone about meals in your country?
During meals it's important to ...
- 3 What is a polite way to greet someone in your country? What other greetings do you know from around the world?
Men and women greet each other by ...

GLOBAL POLITENESS



Australia

Arriving on time to meet people is very important.



Brazil

It is OK to be a little late.



Greece

Shake hands when you meet people and to say goodbye.



Morocco

It is polite to offer fresh mint tea to visitors.



Poland

Bread and salt are used to welcome important guests.



Japan

You should remove your shoes when you enter someone's home.



U.K.

Sometimes people don't make eye contact during a conversation.

VIDEO



TABLE MANNERS

Before you watch

Work with a partner. Discuss the following situations. Are there any rules about polite behavior in your culture?

- 1 Putting your arms on the table at dinner.
- 2 Bringing a present for your host.
- 3 The way you eat your food.



Traditional Japanese business greeting.

While you watch

Read the questions and then watch the video. Circle the correct answers.

- 1 The students are attending classes in
 - a manners.
 - b international business.
- 2 Which one of these is not a rule of the classes?
 - a To not put your elbows on the table
 - b To move the chair for a guest
- 3 The cost of the classes is
 - a \$75 an hour.
 - b \$75 for 16 weeks.

After you watch

Answer the questions with a partner.

- 1 Do you think it's important to learn about other cultures?
Yes, because ...
- 2 What things are different in your culture to other cultures?
In my culture we ...
- 3 Imagine you work for an international company. Would you pay for a course to learn about other cultures?

1 READING

What does *polite* mean to you?

A Vocabulary preview

1 Complete the sentences with the words in the box.

behavior consider judge manners rude smiling social media tip

- 1 Some people think it is _____ to speak loudly on your phone in public.
 - 2 _____ has changed the way people communicate. Some people think connecting online has made people less polite.
 - 3 Our _____, the way we act, affects people's opinions of us.
 - 4 It is good _____ to hold a door open for someone.
 - 5 We _____ people by how they act as much as by what they say.
 - 6 _____ is a helpful way to show we are friendly, or to make others feel relaxed.
 - 7 It is important to _____ when the service is good.
 - 8 We don't all _____ politeness to be important.
- 2 Check (✓) the sentences you agree with. Compare your opinions with a partner.

B Before you read

1 Look at these behaviors. Choose how acceptable the behavior is.

	Very rude					It's fine
Speaking on your phone on public transportation	10	8	6	4	2	1
Interrupting someone	10	8	6	4	2	1
Using your left hand to greet someone	10	8	6	4	2	1
Sending e-mails during a meeting	10	8	6	4	2	1

2 Compare your choices with a partner. Give reasons for your choice.

Preparing to read

What does *polite* mean to you?

READING 1

- 1 In many countries around the world, no matter what generation you are, there are some key things that are considered polite behavior. Turning your phone off at dinner, turning it down on public transportation, not interrupting colleagues, saying please and thank you, and offering seats to those less able to stand than you are all considered appropriate and polite behavior in many cultures. Although most people agree these behaviors are polite, there is a big difference in politeness between the generations. It was once considered polite to stand when someone left the dinner table, but this is no longer the case. Additionally, older generations are the most likely to judge someone's politeness, but what other factors influence politeness in society?
- 2 While languages change over time in terms of words being added or taken away, they also change in terms of their structure and use. Some phrases are not really used for their actual meaning but as polite social phrases. For example, when someone says "thank you," how should we reply? Older people are more likely to say "You're welcome," whereas younger people are more likely to say "No problem." The concepts of polite behavior don't just vary by age, they also vary by geographic location. How we display polite behavior in one place is quite different in another.
- 3 From tipping, to smiling, and how you eat, there are different ways to show politeness across the world. Take tipping for instance, which is polite and expected in countries such as the U.S.A. However, in Japan tipping is not expected in any situation and may even create a difficult situation by offending someone. The hand you use to do different things is not important in most European cultures, but in India the left hand is considered unclean and shouldn't be used to eat, greet, or exchange money. Some people now even argue that asking for directions is rude. People have phones for that and should not need to interrupt other people.
- 4 This is not the only influence technology is having on what is considered polite behavior. Cell phones have changed what is considered polite behavior in many situations. To some people even just having your phone at the dinner table is thought to be impolite. An even greater number are likely to consider speaking on the phone during dinner as rude. However, some people argue that there are differences in this depending on people's age. Take sending e-mails in a meeting from your phone. Many younger people are likely to consider this as acceptable whereas older people are much more likely to have a negative reaction and find this rude. Overall those under 30 are arguably much more tolerant of people using cell devices at a meal, during a meeting, or in a class. Younger generations simply have a different perspective on what is socially acceptable behavior when it comes to using technology. Digital devices are not only changing how we behave but also what we consider polite behavior.
- 5 The concept of politeness varies greatly across cultures and generations. What is acceptable in one context may cause great offence in another. Adapting our behavior to suit other people and the situation is a skill we all need to learn.



GLOSSARY

offend (v) to make someone upset and angry by doing or saying something

1 READING

Using topic sentences to understand main ideas

Scanning

C Global reading

Topic sentences are usually one of the first two sentences of each paragraph. They contain the main idea of the paragraph and everything in that paragraph should support the main idea. Reading topic sentences is a good way to scan a text quickly.

- 1 Read *What does polite mean to you?* and underline the topic sentences in paragraphs 2–4.
- 2 Match the main ideas below with paragraphs 2–4.
 - A People use different phrases for politeness. ____
 - B Technology has changed what is thought of as polite. ____
 - C Politeness varies across cultures. ____

D Close reading

Read *What does polite mean to you?* again and complete the paragraph.

The attitudes to polite behavior change depending on age, but also on geography. For example, in response to “thank you,” older people are likely to say ¹_____ and younger generations would say ²_____. In other countries, customs change too: ³_____ is not common in Japan, and in India you shouldn’t use your ⁴_____ for eating or greeting. Recently, technology has also changed our polite behavior norms. A few people think ⁵_____ with you while you eat is rude, and ⁶_____ often do not think it’s OK to send e-mails during a meeting.

E Critical thinking

- 1 What behavior do you find rude in other people? Do you think other people would find any of your behavior rude?
I really dislike it when ...
- 2 Do you think younger people are less polite than older people?
Why / why not?
I do / don’t think so because ...